

# GUM/TEETH SYMPTOMS

## Give urgent attention to the patient with gum/teeth symptoms and any of:

- Temperature  $\geq 38^{\circ}\text{C}$  and swelling of face/jaw/next to tooth
- Unable to eat or drink
- Tooth pain that is felt without touching tooth/gum or that wakes patient at night

Refer urgently.



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## Approach to the patient with gum/teeth symptoms not needing urgent attention:

- Is there tooth pain, red or bleeding/enlarged gums?
- Look in mouth: lift lips to look at teeth and gums:

Brown/black staining of teeth at gumline, holes, pits or missing teeth. May have tooth pain with hot or cold food/drink.



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### Dental caries likely

- Advise patient to care for his/her mouth (below).
- Refer to dentist.

Gums red/bleeding or enlarged



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### Gum problem likely

- Advise patient to care for his/her mouth (below).
- Review medication: phenytoin and amlodipine may cause gum overgrowth. Discuss with doctor.
- Rinse mouth with salt water mouthwash<sup>1</sup> for 1 minute twice a day.
- If no better with good mouth care, rinse with **chlorhexidine 0.2%** mouthwash twice a day for 5 days, after brushing teeth:
  - Swirl in mouth but do not swallow.
  - Avoid repeated use as can damage teeth.
  - Advise to avoid eating/drinking for 30 minutes after rinsing.
- Give as needed for pain **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) for up to 5 days.
- Refer to dentist if:
  - No better after 5 days
  - Foul-smelling breath
  - Swollen gums
  - Temperature  $\geq 38^{\circ}\text{C}$
  - Mobile teeth
  - Loss of gum or bone around tooth
  - HIV or diabetes

Previous/current tooth pain with pus in mouth, swelling next to tooth



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### Dental abscess likely

- Give **paracetamol** 1g 4-6 hourly (up to 4g in 24 hours) for up to 5 days.
- Give **amoxicillin** 500mg 8 hourly for 5 days. If penicillin allergic, give instead **azithromycin** 500mg daily for 3 days.
- Give **metronidazole**<sup>2</sup> 400mg 8 hourly for 5 days.
- Refer to dentist.
- Advise to return and refer urgently if symptoms worsen, temperature  $\geq 38^{\circ}\text{C}$  or no better after 2 days.
- Refer same day if > 65 years, alcohol/drug misuse, HIV or diabetes.

## Advise the patient with gum/teeth symptoms to care for his/her mouth

- Advise a healthy diet ↗ 11.
- Advise to brush and floss teeth twice a day.
- If dentures, advise to clean thoroughly every day. If poorly fitting dentures or discomfort, refer to dentist.
- Ask about smoking and alcohol/drug use. If patient smokes, encourage to stop ↗ 141. If alcohol/drug use ↗ 142.

Health for All

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<sup>1</sup>Mix ½ teaspoon salt in ½ cup lukewarm water. <sup>2</sup>Advise no alcohol until 24 hours after last dose of metronidazole.